

I42 Bartimaeus

A blind beggar who would not be silenced, received his sight, and followed Jesus.

Bartimaeus was a blind man who sat begging by the road outside Jericho. When he heard that Jesus of Nazareth was passing by, he began to shout, "Jesus, thou son of David, have mercy on me." The crowd told him to be quiet, but he shouted all the more. Jesus stopped and called for him. Bartimaeus threw off his cloak, jumped up, and came. Jesus asked what he wanted, and he said simply that he wanted to see. Jesus told him his faith had made him whole, and at once he could see. Then he followed Jesus on the road to Jerusalem. Mark alone gives his name, perhaps because early Christians knew him.

At a glance

Name	Bartimaeus, "the son of Timaeus" (Mark 10:46)
Situation	Blind, sitting "by the highway side begging" (Mark 10:46)
Place	The road at Jericho
When	c. AD 30, on Jesus' last journey to Jerusalem
Called Jesus	"Son of David," a title for the Messiah (Mark 10:47)
After his healing	"Followed Jesus in the way" (Mark 10:52)
Main passages	Mark 10:46–52; Matthew 20:29–34; Luke 18:35–43

"And Jesus said unto him, Go thy way; thy faith hath made thee whole. And immediately he received his sight, and followed Jesus in the way."

Mark 10:52, KJV

The life of Bartimaeus

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. Mark sets the healing as Jesus leaves Jericho, just days before he enters Jerusalem.

- c. AD 30

Leaving Jericho

● Cries out

A great crowd follows Jesus out of Jericho. Blind Bartimaeus hears that it is Jesus of Nazareth and cries out, "Jesus, thou son of David, have mercy on me." *Mark 10:46-47*
- On the road

● Refuses to be silenced

Many in the crowd sternly tell him to hold his peace. Instead, he cries out "the more a great deal," calling again on the Son of David for mercy. *Mark 10:48*
- On the road

● Called

Jesus stands still and tells them to call him. The people say, "Be of good comfort, rise; he calleth thee." Casting away his garment, Bartimaeus rises and comes to Jesus. *Mark 10:49-50*
- On the road

● Sees and follows

Jesus asks, "What wilt thou that I should do unto thee?" He answers, "Lord, that I might receive my sight." He is healed at once and follows Jesus. *Mark 10:51-52*

Group notes

Key activities

Matthew tells of two blind men, and Luke places the healing as Jesus comes near Jericho rather than as he leaves. Suggested explanations include the two Jerichos of the time, the old town and Herod's newer one nearby, or Mark naming only the better-known man. Christians differ on how best to fit the accounts together.

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- 1 **Listened.** Though he could not see, he heard who was passing and knew what it meant. *Mark 10:47*
 - 2 **Called Jesus Son of David.** He used a royal title for the Messiah before anyone in the crowd did. *Mark 10:47*
 - 3 **Persisted.** When many told him to be quiet, he cried out even louder. *Mark 10:48*
 - 4 **Threw off his garment.** He cast away his cloak and came to Jesus at once. *Mark 10:50*
 - 5 **Asked plainly.** He named exactly what he wanted: to receive his sight. *Mark 10:51*
 - 6 **Followed.** Once he could see, he followed Jesus along the road toward Jerusalem. *Mark 10:52*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Bartimaeus.

Old Testament

2 Samuel 7:12-16	David's lasting throne, behind the title "son of David"
Echo: Psalm 146:8; Isaiah 35:5; 42:7	The LORD opens the eyes of the blind

New Testament

Mark 10:46-52	The main account, which alone gives his name
Matthew 20:29-34	Two blind men by the way side, whom Jesus touches
Luke 18:35-43	A blind man near Jericho healed; the people praise God
Luke 4:18	Jesus sent to preach "recovering of sight to the blind"
Echo: Mark 10:36	Jesus asks James and John a similar question
Echo: John 9:1-7	Jesus heals a man born blind

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Bartimaeus do when the crowd told him to be quiet (Mark 10:48)?
2. *Understand:* Jesus could see that he was blind. Why do you think he still asked, "What wilt thou that I should do unto thee?"
3. *Apply:* If Jesus asked you that same question today, what would you honestly say?
4. *Apply:* Bartimaeus threw off his cloak to come to Jesus. What would you need to set aside this week to follow Jesus more closely?